
Disclosing Counterfeit Networks: The International Association of Museum Officials in Defence Against Counterfeiting and Improper Trade Practices, c. 1900 – 1945

Jaap Geraerts^{*†1} and Demival Vasques Filho^{*‡2}

¹Leibniz Institute of European History – Germany

²University of Luxembourg – Luxembourg

Abstract

Art forgeries have the potential both to tarnish the reputation of experts, distort art historical research, and inflict economic damage.(i) The recognition of their deceptive qualities and their central role in fraudulent practices spurred initiatives to curb the spread of forgeries. One such initiative was the establishment of the "International Association of Museum Officials in Defence Against Counterfeiting and Improper Trade Practices." (ii) In the Association's journal – the *Mittheilungen des Museen-Verbandes*, published between 1899 and 1939 – information about deceitful objects and practices was shared among its members in over 800 dense entries.(iii)

The project "Forgeries and Networks (ForNet)" (iv) studies the inner workings of this Association as well as the deceitful practices it sought to combat and assesses the efficacy of its endeavours. ForNet does so by uncovering the networks comprising forgers and their forgeries on the one hand, and the members of the Association on the other, while also examining the overlap between them. In order to make this possible, the relevant information in the *Mittheilungen* is captured in XML and modelled in such a way so as to enable the creation of various networks that allow one to discern patterns in this granular and complex dataset. This paper discusses both the challenges of modelling the data and creating two-mode networks,(v) while also showing the heuristic value of applying network analysis in relation to the central questions formulated by the ForNet project.

(i) Henry Keazor, *Täuschend echt!: Eine Geschichte der Kunstfälschung* (Herder, 2015). *Id.*, "Fälschungen (in) der Kunstgeschichte," *Art value – Positionen zum Wert der Kunst* 5:8 (2011), 38-41. <https://doi.org/10.11588/artdok.00002481>.

(ii) O. Kirsch, "Association of museum workers in defence against counterfeiting and unfair trade practices: Comments on the origins of organised meetings of museum workers on an international basis," *Museologica Brunensia* 4:2 (2015), 48-55. <https://hdl.handle.net/11222.digilib/134748>

(iii) A digitized copy of the journal can be accessed here: <https://digi.ub.uni-heidelberg.de/diglit/mitmusverb>.

^{*}Speaker

[†]Corresponding author: geraerts@ieg-mainz.de

[‡]Corresponding author: demival.vasques@uni.lu

(iv) <https://forgeries-and-networks.github.io/ForNetWeb/about-the-project.html>

(v) D. Vasques Filho and D.R. O’Neale, "Transitivity and degree assortativity explained: The bipartite structure of social networks," *Physical Review E* 101:5, 052305. <https://doi.org/10.1103/PhysRevE.101.052305>

Keywords: art forgery, XML, two mode networks, network analysis